

Alfresco: The Open Source Answer to SharePoint

Much has been said about how SharePoint makes working in a team easy and collaboration among team mates effortless. But for the open source community, SharePoint is proprietary software. So, what's the alternative? This article looks at one of the most-talked-about options, Alfresco, to evaluate its potential to stand up to SharePoint.



Let's look at the main features of Alfresco, which make it a suitable alternative to SharePoint.

Web content sharing

One of Alfresco's main features is that it allows Web content sharing. It lets you create a website where the project team can collaborate, share documents and information, schedule meetings, and do much more. Creating the site is as simple as it gets, using the Alfresco GUI. Once you log in to the admin panel, just go to *Sites > Create site*. This opens a window (Figure 1). Fill in the details and get started. Once the site is created, it takes you to the site dashboard, where you can add content, share documents, invite people (the *'Invite'* button is at the top right) and personalise your site. The *'Document Library'* button on the menu lets you add and share documents. There is provision for fine-tuned access control here, letting you manage who accesses what and up to what level (read, write or

both). The ‘*Customise Dashboard*’ button next to ‘*Invite*’ lets you customise the site; you can add dash-lets (small widgets for different activities), and also arrange their position and display format (one column, two columns and so on). Figure 2 shows the dashboard. As you explore, you will find there is a lot more to content sharing in Alfresco.

Document management and collaboration

Document management is another important feature of Alfresco. You will find the *'Repository'* button in the top menu bar (in the admin/user dashboard). The repository is where you can share and manage all the documents of your installation. If you want to add a document specifically to a site, you can go to the site dashboard (not the admin dashboard) and then the link *'Document Library'*. Here, you can add (even drag and drop) new folders or new documents. Once the document is added, you can fine-tune the permissions—select the document or folder you want to modify, and click *'Selected Items'* (see Figure 3).



Figure 1: Add a site here



Figure 2: The site dashboard